

Loneliness, Hopelessness, and Meaning in Life among Young Adults Following a Romantic Breakup

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Abstract

This study examined the relationships and predictive contributions of loneliness and hopelessness to meaning in life among young adults following a romantic breakup. A quantitative correlational design was employed using an online questionnaire distributed to individuals aged 20–25 years who had experienced the end of a romantic relationship lasting at least six months. Of the 81 responses received, 67 met the eligibility criteria and were included in the analysis. Data were analyzed using Pearson's correlation, multiple linear regression, and supplementary analyses of the Presence of Meaning and Search for Meaning dimensions. The results showed that loneliness was negatively associated with meaning in life, although it did not make a significant unique contribution when hopelessness was included in the regression model. Hopelessness, in contrast, emerged as a significant negative predictor and the strongest variable in the model. Together, loneliness and hopelessness explained 49.2% of the variance in meaning in life. Additional findings indicated that hopelessness was more strongly related to the Presence of Meaning than to the Search for Meaning. These results suggest that meaning in life after a romantic breakup is more closely associated with hope, future orientation, and confidence in the possibility of a better life than with loneliness alone.

Keywords: Hopelessness; Loneliness; Meaning in Life; Romantic Breakup; Young Adults

1. Introduction

Meaning in life is a psychological construct that enables individuals to understand the purpose, direction, and value of their lives. Individuals who perceive their lives as meaningful are generally better able to interpret life experiences constructively, maintain psychological stability, and adjust to stressful events. [Frankl \(2006\)](#) argued that the pursuit of meaning is a fundamental human motivation, particularly during periods of hardship, loss, and uncertainty. Similarly, [Steger et al. \(2006\)](#) conceptualized meaning in life as the extent to which individuals perceive their lives as meaningful and purposeful while also seeking to understand and develop such meaning. Therefore, meaning in life involves not only having clear life goals but also the capacity to reconstruct one's sense of direction following psychologically disruptive

experiences.

Meaning in life is particularly important during early adulthood, a developmental period characterized by identity exploration, emotional independence, career preparation, and the formation of intimate romantic relationships ([Arnett, 2015](#)). At this stage, romantic relationships extend beyond emotional attachment because they often contribute to identity formation, social support, a sense of belonging, and future planning. The end of a romantic relationship may therefore involve the loss of an attachment figure who previously provided emotional security, intimacy, and psychological support. [Park \(2010\)](#) explained that significant life events can disrupt an individual's meaning system, especially when those experiences conflict with previously established expectations, goals, or life plans. Consequently, a romantic breakup may represent both an emotional and an existential experience that challenges young adults' ability to preserve or reconstruct meaning in life.

Psychological adjustment is shaped not only by internal resources but also by the pressures individuals encounter in their social and occupational environments. [Rahayu and Bernadus \(2026\)](#). [Ekanesia et al. \(2024\)](#) found that perceived social support was associated with adolescent mental health, while [Aeni et al. \(2024\)](#) reported that perceived social support and optimism contributed to subjective well-being. [Putra and Nuradina \(2023\)](#) further emphasized the importance of coping and resilience in helping individuals adapt to stressful circumstances. The relevance of this issue is also supported by the demographic context of Bandung. According to Statistics Bandung Municipality ([BPS Kota Bandung, 2020](#)), individuals of productive age constitute a substantial proportion of the city's population, including young adults who are navigating identity development, social relationships, romantic involvement, and future planning. Examining romantic breakups among young adults in the Bandung area is therefore important for understanding how individuals maintain or rebuild meaning after relational loss.

One psychological condition that may be associated with meaning in life following a romantic breakup is loneliness. Loneliness refers to an unpleasant subjective experience that emerges when individuals perceive a discrepancy between the social relationships they desire and those they actually have ([Perlman & Peplau, 1981](#)). [Russell \(1996\)](#) noted that loneliness is not merely the absence of social interaction, but also involves feelings of isolation, insufficient emotional intimacy, and dissatisfaction with existing relationships. After a romantic breakup, loneliness may arise because individuals lose someone who previously served as a source of emotional closeness, comfort, and understanding. This condition is relevant to meaning in life because social relationships provide an important foundation for belonging, purpose, and personal significance. [Tam and Chan \(2019\)](#) found that a lack of meaning was associated with loneliness, whereas [Lambert et al. \(2013\)](#) demonstrated that social connectedness contributes to the perception that life is meaningful.

Hopelessness is another psychological condition that may be closely related to meaning in life. It refers to a negative cognitive orientation toward the future, characterized by pessimistic expectations, diminished hope, and the belief that undesirable circumstances are unlikely to improve ([Beck et al., 1974](#); [Beck, 1986](#)). Following the end of a romantic relationship, individuals may lose not only emotional intimacy but also plans, aspirations, and expectations that were previously associated with the relationship. Such losses may lead them to view the future as uncertain, disappointing, or devoid of meaning. Hopelessness is therefore closely connected to meaning in life because both constructs involve life goals, expectations, and future orientation.

Although previous studies have examined loneliness, hopelessness, social support, resilience, and psychological well-being, limited research has specifically investigated the relationships and predictive contributions of loneliness and hopelessness to meaning in life among young adults after a romantic breakup, particularly in urban Indonesian settings. Existing studies have more frequently focused on general student populations, clinical groups, workplace settings, or broader indicators of psychological well-being. Romantic breakup experiences have also commonly been approached as emotional or interpersonal problems rather than as existential events that may require individuals to reconstruct their sense of meaning.

Accordingly, this study aims to examine the relationships and predictive contributions of loneliness and hopelessness to meaning in life among young adults who have experienced a romantic breakup in the Bandung area. Theoretically, loneliness represents the relational and emotional dimension of post-breakup adjustment, whereas hopelessness reflects the cognitive and future-oriented dimension. The contribution of this study lies in positioning romantic breakup not only as an emotional disruption but also as an existential experience related to the reconstruction of life meaning. The findings are expected to provide an empirical basis for psychological interventions, counseling services, and support programs designed for young adults adapting to the loss of a romantic relationship.

2. Literature Review

2.1 *Meaning in Life*

Meaning in life is a psychological construct that reflects the extent to which individuals perceive their lives as purposeful, valuable, and clearly directed. [Frankl \(2006\)](#) viewed the search for meaning as a central human motivation, particularly when individuals are confronted with adversity, loss, or suffering. [Steger et al. \(2006\)](#) further distinguished meaning in life into two dimensions: presence of meaning and search for meaning. Presence of meaning refers to the degree to which individuals feel that their lives already possess significance and purpose, whereas the search for meaning represents an active effort to discover, develop, or deepen that sense of meaning.

Meaning in life is especially relevant during early adulthood because this developmental stage involves identity exploration, the formation of intimate relationships, and future planning ([Arnett, 2015](#)). The end of a romantic relationship may disrupt the meaning system that individuals previously developed with their partners. [Park \(2010\)](#) explained that major life events can challenge an individual's established assumptions, goals, and sense of coherence, thereby creating a need to reconstruct meaning. In this context, meaning in life among young adults after a romantic breakup may be understood as their capacity to preserve or rebuild a sense of purpose, direction, and personal value following relational loss.

2.2 *Loneliness and Meaning in Life*

Loneliness is a subjective and distressing experience that arises when individuals perceive a gap between the social relationships they expect and those they actually have. [Perlman and Peplau \(1981\)](#) described loneliness as an unpleasant condition resulting from unmet relational needs, while [Russell \(1996\)](#) emphasized that it is shaped not only by the number of social contacts but also by the quality of emotional closeness within those relationships.

Following a romantic breakup, loneliness may emerge when individuals lose someone who previously provided emotional security, companionship, and a space to share personal experiences. During early adulthood, romantic relationships often contribute substantially to

identity development, intimacy, and future planning ([Arnett, 2015](#)). Social support has also been shown to be associated with the mental health of young people ([Ekanesia et al., 2024](#)), suggesting that the loss of an important source of emotional support may be linked to poorer psychological adjustment.

Loneliness may be negatively associated with meaning in life because social connection is an important source of belonging, purpose, and personal significance. [Lambert et al. \(2013\)](#) found that a stronger sense of belonging enhances perceived meaning in life, whereas [Tam and Chan \(2019\)](#) reported that a lack of meaning is associated with greater loneliness. On this basis, loneliness is expected to be negatively related to meaning in life among young adults who have experienced a romantic breakup.

2.3 Hopelessness and Meaning in Life

Hopelessness is a negative cognitive state characterized by pessimistic expectations, diminished hope, and the belief that undesirable circumstances are unlikely to improve. [Beck et al. \(1974\)](#) conceptualized hopelessness as a pattern of negative expectations concerning the future and a belief that personal efforts will not lead to meaningful change. [Beck \(1986\)](#) similarly noted that individuals who feel hopeless tend to view the future as bleak and perceive themselves as having little control over their circumstances.

In the context of a romantic breakup, hopelessness may arise not only from the loss of the relationship itself but also from the collapse of shared plans, anticipated futures, and personal expectations tied to the relationship. Meaning in life is closely connected to hopelessness because both constructs involve purpose, direction, and beliefs about whether life remains worth pursuing. [Steger et al. \(2006\)](#) linked meaning in life to both the presence and pursuit of purpose, while [Ryff and Singer \(1996\)](#) identified purpose in life as a central component of psychological well-being. [Mukaromah and Sastri \(2025\)](#) also found that future orientation plays an important role in students' psychological well-being. Therefore, hopelessness is expected to be negatively associated with meaning in life among young adults following a romantic breakup.

2.4 Loneliness, Hopelessness, and Meaning in Life

Loneliness and hopelessness represent two distinct but related psychological dimensions of adjustment after a romantic breakup. Loneliness reflects the relational and emotional consequences of losing intimacy and connectedness, whereas hopelessness reflects a cognitive and future-oriented decline in hope, purpose, and confidence that life can improve. Both are relevant because the consequences of a romantic breakup involve not only present emotional distress but also the way individuals interpret their future and evaluate the meaning of their lives.

Previous findings indicate that social support and optimism contribute to subjective well-being ([Aeni et al., 2024](#)), while coping and resilience assist individuals in adapting to stressful experiences ([Putra & Nuradina, 2023](#)). Similarly, [Putri and Sastri \(2026\)](#) highlighted the relevance of self-adjustment and stress-coping mechanisms in helping individuals manage demanding psychological circumstances. These findings suggest that meaning in life after a romantic breakup may be shaped by both social connectedness and the psychological resources used to respond to loss.

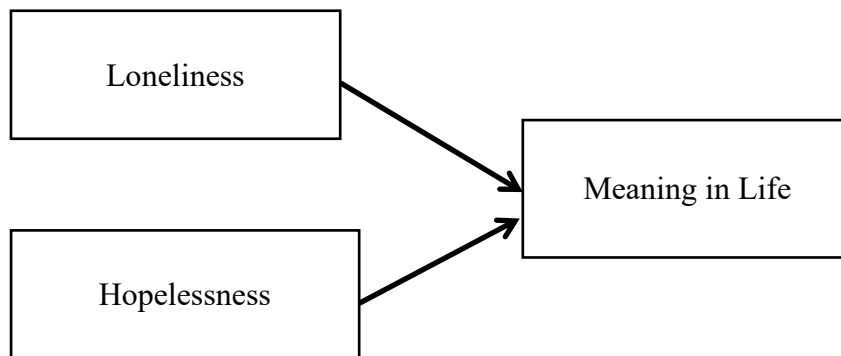


Figure 1. Conceptual Framework of the Study

Source: Authors' elaboration, 2026

3. Research Method

3.1 Desain Penelitian

This study employed a quantitative, correlational research design. The design was selected to examine the direction and strength of the relationships among loneliness, hopelessness, and meaning in life in young adults who had experienced the end of a romantic relationship.

Loneliness and hopelessness were treated as predictor variables, whereas meaning in life was treated as the criterion variable. Data were collected via an online questionnaire. Pearson's correlation analysis served as the primary statistical procedure for examining relationships among the study variables. Multiple linear regression was subsequently conducted to assess the predictive contributions of loneliness and hopelessness to meaning in life when both predictors were entered simultaneously into the model. The regression analysis was intended for predictive purposes and was not used to establish causal relationships.

3.2 Population and Sample

The study population consisted of young adults aged 20–25 years who had previously experienced a romantic breakup. Because the exact size of this population was unknown and no official records were available, a non-probability sampling approach was applied. Participants were recruited through purposive sampling, supported by snowball sampling. Eligible individuals were selected according to predetermined criteria, and the questionnaire link was then shared with other potential participants who had undergone similar experiences.

Participants were required to meet four inclusion criteria: (1) being between 20 and 25 years of age; (2) having experienced the end of a non-marital romantic relationship; (3) having been involved in the previous relationship for at least six months; and (4) agreeing to participate voluntarily. A total of 81 responses were received, of which 67 met the eligibility criteria and were included in the primary analysis. This number exceeded the minimum sample size recommended for multiple linear regression based on the formula proposed by [Tabachnick and Fidell, \(2019\)](#). With two predictor variables, the minimum required sample was 66 participants.

3.3 Research Instruments

Data were collected using a questionnaire comprising three psychological measures: loneliness, hopelessness, and meaning in life. All items were rated on a four-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = Strongly Disagree to 4 = Strongly Agree. Positively worded items were scored according to the response order, whereas negatively worded items were reverse-scored. The

instruments used in the study are summarized in Table 2.

Table 2. Research Instruments

Variable	Measurement Basis		Dimension	Number of Items	Scale
Loneliness	UCLA	Loneliness Scale Version 3	Unidimensional	15	Four-point Likert scale
Hopelessness	Beck	Hopelessness Scale	Unidimensional	15	Four-point Likert scale
Meaning in Life	Meaning in Life Questionnaire		Presence of Meaning and Search for Meaning	15	Four-point Likert scale

As presented in Table 2, the loneliness scale assessed feelings of social isolation, insufficient emotional closeness, and dissatisfaction with social relationships. The hopelessness scale measured negative expectations about the future, diminished hope, and the belief that current difficulties were unlikely to improve. The meaning in life scale assessed the extent to which participants perceived their lives as meaningful and purposeful and the degree to which they sought to reconstruct meaning following a romantic breakup.

Although the Meaning in Life Questionnaire consists of two dimensions, namely Presence of Meaning and Search for Meaning, the total meaning in life score was used as the primary criterion variable. This approach was adopted because the study examined meaning in life as an overall psychological construct. Additional analyses of Presence of Meaning and Search for Meaning were conducted to identify more specific patterns in the relationships and predictive contributions of loneliness and hopelessness to each dimension.

3.4 Data Analysis

The data analysis involved data screening, coding, reverse scoring of negatively worded items, item analysis, internal consistency assessment, examination of regression assumptions, Pearson's correlation analysis, and multiple linear regression. Item performance was evaluated using corrected item–total correlations, also referred to as item–rest correlations, to examine the extent to which each item was consistent with the remaining items in its respective scale. Items with corrected item–total correlations below .30 were reviewed and removed when their exclusion improved the internal consistency and conceptual coherence of the scale. Internal consistency was assessed using Cronbach's alpha, with coefficients of .70 or higher interpreted as indicating acceptable reliability.

Pearson's correlation analysis was used to determine the direction and strength of the relationships among loneliness, hopelessness, and meaning in life. Multiple linear regression was subsequently conducted as a supplementary predictive analysis to examine the unique contributions of loneliness and hopelessness in explaining variation in meaning in life when both predictors were entered simultaneously. Additional regression analyses were performed for the Presence of Meaning and Search for Meaning dimensions to identify dimension-specific predictive patterns.

4. Findings and Discussions

4.1 Findings

4.1.1 Participant Characteristics

A total of 81 responses were collected through the online questionnaire. Following eligibility screening, 67 participants met the inclusion criteria and were retained for the primary analysis. Responses were excluded when participants were outside the required age range of 20–25 years, had never experienced the end of a romantic relationship, or had been involved in the previous relationship for less than six months. The demographic and relationship-related characteristics of the participants are presented in Table 3.

Table 3. Participant Characteristics

Characteristic	Category	Frequency	Percentage
Gender	Female	39	58.2%
	Male	28	41.8%
Age	20 years	9	13.4%
	21 years	7	10.4%
	22 years	21	31.3%
	23 years	12	17.9%
	24 years	9	13.4%
	25 years	9	13.4%
Current relationship status	Dating	52	77.6%
	Undefined relationship	8	11.9%
	Engaged	4	6.0%
	Married	3	4.5%
Person who ended the previous relationship	Participant ended the relationship	36	53.7%
	Partner ended the relationship	31	46.3%
Duration of the previous relationship	6–12 months	31	46.3%
	More than 12 months	36	53.7%
Place of residence	Bandung Municipality	41	61.2%
	Bandung Regency	18	26.9%
	Cimahi Municipality	8	11.9%
Total		67	100.0%

As shown in Table 3, most participants were female (58.2%), and the largest age group consisted of 22-year-olds (31.3%). Most participants resided in Bandung Municipality (61.2%), followed by Bandung Regency (26.9%) and Cimahi Municipality (11.9%). At the time of data collection, 77.6% were in a new dating relationship. Slightly more than half had previously been involved in a relationship lasting longer than 12 months (53.7%). The proportions of participants who ended the previous relationship and those whose partners ended it were relatively balanced, at 53.7% and 46.3%, respectively.

4.1.2 Item Analysis and Reliability

Corrected item–total correlations were examined to evaluate the consistency of each item with the remaining items in its respective scale. Items with coefficients below .30 were reviewed for removal by considering both their statistical performance and conceptual relevance. Internal consistency was assessed using Cronbach’s alpha, with coefficients of .70 or higher interpreted as acceptable. The results of the item analysis and internal consistency assessment are

presented in Table 4.

Table 4. Validity and Reliability Results

Variable	Initial Number of Items	Invalid Items	Valid Items	Cronbach's Alpha after Item Removal	Interpretation
Loneliness	15	1	14	.897	Reliable
Hopelessness	15	1	14	.944	Reliable
Meaning in Life	15	1	14	.889	Reliable

Each measure contained one item that failed to meet the validity criterion and was therefore excluded from subsequent analyses. After item removal, all three measures demonstrated strong internal consistency. Cronbach's alpha values were .897 for loneliness, .944 for hopelessness, and .889 for meaning in life. These results indicate that the retained items were sufficiently reliable for further statistical analysis.

4.1.3 Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics were calculated to identify the overall distribution of loneliness, hopelessness, and meaning in life scores. The results are presented in Table 5.

Table 5. Descriptive Statistics of the Study Variables

Variable	N	Valid Items	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	SD	Mean / Item	General Category
Loneliness	67	14	15	55	32.72	8.78	2.34	Moderate
Hopelessness	67	14	14	54	26.03	10.01	1.86	Low
Meaning in Life	67	14	17	56	43.67	7.74	3.12	High

The mean loneliness score was 32.72, with an item-level mean of 2.34, indicating a moderate overall level. Hopelessness had a mean score of 26.03 and an item-level mean of 1.86, placing it in the low category. Meaning in life had a mean score of 43.67 and an item-level mean of 3.12, indicating a generally high level among the participants.

The categorical distribution of each variable is presented in Table 6.

Table 6. Distribution of Variable Categories

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage
Loneliness	Low	19	28.4%
	Moderate	39	58.2%
	High	9	13.4%
Hopelessness	Low	39	58.2%
	Moderate	21	31.3%
	High	7	10.4%
Meaning in Life	Low	2	3.0%
	Moderate	22	32.8%
	High	43	64.2%

Table 6 shows that most participants reported moderate loneliness (58.2%), low hopelessness (58.2%), and high meaning in life (64.2%). Thus, although many participants continued to experience a moderate degree of loneliness after the breakup, most maintained a relatively strong sense of meaning and reported limited hopelessness.

4.1.4 Regression Assumption Testing

Before conducting multiple linear regression, the assumptions of normality, multicollinearity, and homoscedasticity were evaluated. The results are presented in Table 7.

Table 7. Results of Regression Assumption Testing

Assumption	Indicator	Result	Interpretation
Normality	Shapiro–Wilk, (p)	.244	Residuals were normally distributed
Normality	Kolmogorov–Smirnov, (p)	.774	Residuals were normally distributed
Multicollinearity	Tolerance: Loneliness	.475	No multicollinearity
Multicollinearity	VIF: Loneliness	2.106	No multicollinearity
Multicollinearity	Tolerance: Hopelessness	.475	No multicollinearity
Multicollinearity	VIF: Hopelessness	2.106	No multicollinearity
Heteroscedasticity	Loneliness, (p)	.481	No heteroscedasticity detected
Heteroscedasticity	Hopelessness, (p)	.342	No heteroscedasticity detected

The Shapiro–Wilk and Kolmogorov–Smirnov tests yielded p-values of .244 and .774, respectively. As both values exceeded .05, the regression residuals were considered normally distributed. The tolerance value for each predictor was .475, while the variance inflation factor was 2.106. These values satisfied the recommended criteria of tolerance above .10 and VIF below 10, indicating no problematic multicollinearity. The heteroscedasticity tests were also nonsignificant for loneliness ($p=.481$) and hopelessness ($p=.342$). Therefore, the model met the assumptions required for multiple linear regression.

4.1.5 Pearson Correlation Analysis

Pearson’s correlation analysis was conducted to determine the direction and strength of the relationships among loneliness, hopelessness, and meaning in life. The results are shown in Table 8.

Table 8. Pearson Correlation Results

Variable	Loneliness	Hopelessness	Meaning in Life
Loneliness	1		
Hopelessness	.725	1	
Meaning in Life	-.485	-.700	1

Note. ($p<.01$).

Loneliness was strongly and positively correlated with hopelessness, ($r=.725$), ($p<.01$), indicating that higher loneliness tended to occur alongside greater hopelessness. Loneliness was also moderately and negatively associated with meaning in life, ($r=-.485$), ($p<.01$). Hopelessness demonstrated a stronger negative relationship with meaning in life, ($r=-.700$), ($p<.01$). These findings indicate that hopelessness had a closer bivariate association with meaning in life than loneliness did.

4.1.6 Multiple Linear Regression Analysis

Multiple linear regression was performed as a supplementary analysis to examine the predictive contributions of loneliness and hopelessness to meaning in life when both variables were entered simultaneously. This analysis was used to estimate predictive contribution rather than

to infer causal effects. The results are reported in Table 9.

Table 9. Multiple Linear Regression Results Predicting Meaning in Life

Predictor	B	SE	Beta	t	p	Interpretation
Constant	57.097	2.663		21.440	<.001	Significant
Loneliness	.041	.114	.047	.363	.718	Not significant
Hopelessness	-.568	.100	-.734	-5.677	<.001	Significant

Loneliness did not make a statistically significant unique contribution to meaning in life after hopelessness was included in the model, ($B=.041$), ($\beta=.047$), ($t=.363$), ($p=.718$). Although its regression coefficient was slightly positive, this result should not be interpreted as evidence that loneliness increases meaning in life. The zero-order correlation between loneliness and meaning in life was negative, and the change in direction may reflect the substantial overlap between loneliness and hopelessness.

By contrast, hopelessness made a significant negative contribution to meaning in life, ($B=-.568$), ($\beta=-.734$), ($t=-5.677$), ($p<.001$). Higher hopelessness was therefore associated with lower predicted meaning in life after controlling for loneliness. The standardized coefficient also indicates that hopelessness was the stronger predictor in the model.

The resulting regression equation was:

$$[Y = 57.097 + 0.041X_1 - 0.568X_2]$$

where:

(Y) = Meaning in Life

(X₁) = Loneliness

(X₂) = Hopelessness

(e) = Error term

4.1.7 Predictive Model and Coefficient of Determination

An F test was conducted to evaluate whether the model containing loneliness and hopelessness significantly explained variation in meaning in life.

Table 10. Predictive Model and Coefficient of Determination

R	R ²	Adjusted R ²	F	p	Interpretation
.701	.492	.476	30.930	<.001	Significant

The overall regression model was statistically significant ($F=30.930$), ($p<.001$), indicating that loneliness and hopelessness jointly explained a meaningful proportion of variation in meaning in life. Thus, H3 was supported by the data. The model accounted for 49.2% of the variance in meaning in life, while the remaining 50.8% may be associated with factors not included in the model, such as social support, resilience, religiosity, self-esteem, coping strategies, attachment style, family relationship quality, or the length of time since the breakup.

4.1.8 Dimension-Specific Analysis of Meaning in Life

Additional regression analyses were conducted for the two dimensions of the Meaning in Life Questionnaire, namely Presence of Meaning and Search for Meaning. These analyses examined whether loneliness and hopelessness showed different predictive patterns across the two dimensions. The results are presented in Table 11.

Table 11. Regression Results for the Dimensions of Meaning in Life

Criterion Variable	Predictor	B	Beta	t	p	R ²	Interpretation
Presence of Meaning	Loneliness	-.093	-.152	-1.613	.112	.729	Not significant
	Hopelessness	-.396	-.737	-7.802	<.001		Significant
Search for Meaning	Loneliness	.135	.271	1.553	.125	.074	Not significant
	Hopelessness	-.172	-.395	-2.263	.027		Significant

Hopelessness significantly and negatively predicted Presence of Meaning ($B = -.396$), ($\beta = -.737$), ($t = -7.802$), ($p < .001$), whereas loneliness did not make a significant contribution ($p = .112$). Together, the two predictors explained 72.9% of the variance in Presence of Meaning.

A similar pattern emerged for Search for Meaning. Hopelessness contributed negatively and significantly, ($B = -.172$), ($\beta = -.395$), ($t = -2.263$), ($p = .027$), whereas loneliness was not significant, ($p = .125$). However, the model explained only 7.4% of the variance in Search for Meaning. These findings suggest that hopelessness was more strongly associated with the extent to which individuals already experienced their lives as meaningful than with their active search for meaning.

4.2 Discussion

The findings show that loneliness and hopelessness jointly contributed to predicting meaning in life among young adults following a romantic breakup. These variables reflect two related dimensions of post-breakup adjustment: emotional connectedness and future-oriented cognition. Loneliness captures the relational loss associated with reduced intimacy, whereas hopelessness reflects diminished expectations, purpose, and confidence in the future.

Descriptively, most participants reported moderate loneliness, low hopelessness, and high meaning in life. This pattern should be interpreted in light of the fact that many participants had entered new romantic relationships. A new relationship may restore emotional support, a sense of belonging, and a sense of future orientation. Nevertheless, because no group comparison was conducted based on current relationship status, this explanation should be treated as contextual rather than conclusive.

Loneliness was negatively correlated with meaning in life, but it did not make a significant unique contribution when hopelessness was included in the regression model. This suggests that loneliness remains relevant at the bivariate level, yet its distinct predictive role becomes weaker once shared variance with hopelessness is taken into account. The strong association between loneliness and hopelessness further indicates that emotional disconnection may coexist with pessimistic views of the future.

Hopelessness, by contrast, emerged as the strongest negative predictor of meaning in life. Individuals who perceive the future as bleak may find it more difficult to maintain direction, purpose, and the belief that life remains meaningful. This finding is consistent with [Mukaromah and Sastri \(2025\)](#), who emphasized the role of future orientation in psychological well-being, and with [Putra and Nuradina \(2023\)](#), who highlighted the importance of coping and resilience under stressful conditions.

From [Frankl's \(2006\)](#) perspective, the search for meaning becomes especially important in the face of loss and suffering. Meaning is not determined solely by circumstances, but also by how

individuals respond to those circumstances and identify value within them. Following a romantic breakup, meaning may be reconstructed through new goals, supportive relationships, productive engagement, and a more adaptive stance toward loss. The dominant role of hopelessness therefore supports Frankl's view that a weakened orientation toward the future can undermine the ability to experience life as meaningful.

The dimension-specific analysis further showed that hopelessness was more strongly related to the Presence of Meaning than to the Search for Meaning. This indicates that hopelessness is particularly associated with a reduced sense that life already has purpose and direction, whereas the active search for meaning may depend on a broader range of psychological and social resources. For example, [Gumilar and Akbar \(2026\)](#) found that self-esteem was positively associated with psychological well-being, whereas FOMO was negatively associated. Search for Meaning may therefore also be related to resilience, social support, emotional regulation, religiosity, self-esteem, digital-social experiences, and the length of time since the breakup.

Overall, a romantic breakup should be understood as both an emotional and an existential experience. Psychological support for young adults after a breakup should therefore address not only loneliness, but also hope, future orientation, coping capacity, resilience, and the reconstruction of meaningful life goals.

5. Conclusion

This study examined the relationships and predictive contributions of loneliness and hopelessness to meaning in life among young adults following a romantic breakup. Loneliness was negatively associated with meaning in life, but it did not make a significant unique contribution when hopelessness was included in the regression model. This indicates that loneliness is associated with lower meaning in life, though its predictive role becomes weaker when hopelessness is taken into account.

Hopelessness emerged as the strongest negative predictor of meaning in life. The findings therefore suggest that meaning in life after a romantic breakup is more closely related to hope, future orientation, and confidence in the possibility of a better life than to loneliness alone. Together, loneliness and hopelessness explained a substantial proportion of the variance in meaning in life.

Additional analysis showed that hopelessness was more strongly associated with Presence of Meaning than with Search for Meaning. This suggests that hopelessness is particularly related to a reduced sense that life already has purpose, direction, and significance. Accordingly, support for young adults after a romantic breakup should address not only loneliness but also the restoration of hope and the strengthening of future-oriented life goals.

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